



Who Are the Coupon Crazy?

You've likely seen one on television or in the newspaper—the self-proclaimed “Coupon Queen” who buys 100 dollars' worth of groceries for less than 10 dollars. A March 2010 *Nightline* exclusive featured a shopping duel between two of them: Nathan Engels, a male couponer nicknamed “Mr. Coupon,” who greeted the news crew with the tower he constructed with free boxes of Jell-O, and Jill Cataldo, a “Coupon Queen” who teaches couponing classes in Chicago and writes a nationally syndicated column. Television station TLC built an entire series, *Extreme Couponing*, around the most extreme, and sometimes controversial, of America's coupon users. Maybe you grew up in a house where your mother dutifully clipped every coupon. Perhaps your friend or sister is an avid coupon user. Or maybe, like me, you count yourself among them.

The shopping trips planned for the media are generally set up for spectacular results that might not be typical even for that particular shopper, although depending upon store doubling opportunities, they can be. In regards to the *Extreme Couponing* program, cases of certain products have been ordered ahead of time and shelves stocked in proportions that aren't readily available to the general public. In other words, the average shopper